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Why? said Percy curiously. It's because of you, Perce, said George seriously. And there'll be little flags on the hoods, with HB on them - - for Humongous Bighead, said Fred. CHAPTER ELEVEN THE DUELING CLUB Harry had received two letters from Sirius since he had been back at Privet Drive. Both had been delivered, not by owls (as was usual with wizards), but by large, brightly colored tropical birds. Hedwig had not approved of these flashy intruders; she had been most reluctant to allow them to drink from her water tray before flying off again. Harry, on the other hand, had liked them; they put him in mind of palm trees and white sand, and he hoped that, wherever Sirius was (Sirius never said, in case the letters were intercepted), he was enjoying himself. Somehow, Harry found it hard to imagine dementors surviving for long in bright sunlight; perhaps that was why Sirius had gone south. Sirius's letters, which were now hidden beneath the highly useful loose floorboard under Harry's bed, sounded cheerful, and in both of them he had reminded Harry to call on him if ever Harry needed to. Well, he needed to now, all right... Not the way Lockhart teaches it, said Ron. I haven't learned anything from him except not to set pixies loose. Neville Longbottom had been sent letters from all the witches and wizards in his family, all giving him different advice on what to choose. Confused and worried, he sat reading the subject lists with his tongue poking out, asking people whether they thought Arithmancy sounded more difficult than Study of Ancient Runes. Dean Thomas, who, like Harry, had grown up with Muggles, ended up closing his eyes and jabbing his wand at the list, then picking the subjects it landed on. Hermione took nobody's advice but signed up for everything. Who cares? said Harry and Ron together. Lupin drank it? he gasped. Is he mad? Hermione checked her watch. The quill whizzed across the parchment between them, back and forward as though it were skating.





Not too bad, said Mr. Weasley. We live just on the other side of the village there. You? Had to get up at two, didn't we. Cad? I tell you, I'll be glad when he's got his Apparition test. Still... not complaining... Quidditch World Cup, wouldn't miss it for a sackful of Galleons - and the tickets cost about that. Mind you, looks like I got off easy... Amos Diggory peered good-naturedly around at the three Weasley boys, Harry, Hermione, and Ginny. All these yours, Arthur? Oh no, only the redheads, said Mr. Weasley, pointing out his children. This is Hermione, friend of Ron's - and Harry, another friend - Merlin's beard, said Amos Diggory, his eyes widening. Harry? Harry? The Hogwarts staff, demonstrating a continued desire to impress the visitors from Beauxbatons and Durmstrang, seemed determined to show the castle at its best this Christmas. When the decorations went up, Harry noticed that they were the most stunning he had yet seen inside the school. Everlasting icicles had been attached to the banisters of the marble staircase; the usual twelve Christmas trees in the Great Hall were bedecked with everything from luminous holly berries to real, hooting, golden owls, and the suits of armor had all been bewitched to sing carols whenever anyone passed them. It was quite something to hear O Come, All Ye Faithful sung by an empty helmet that only knew half the words. Several times, Filch the caretaker had to extract Peeves from inside the armor, where he had taken to hiding, filling in the gaps in the songs with lyrics of his own invention, all of which were very rude. Yeah, said Harry, slipping inside the cabin and pulling the Cloak down off his head. What's up? Got summat ter show yeh, said Hagrid. Professor? he said again. Yes, Harry? said Dumbledore. Viktor Krum was standing moodily in a corner as usual and not talking to anybody. Cedric and Fleur were in conversation. Fleur looked a good deal happier than Harry had seen her so far; she kept throwing back her head so that her long silvery hair caught the light. A paunchy man, holding a large black camera that was smoking slightly, was watching Fleur out of the corner of his eye. I'm half-and-half, said Seamus. Me dad's a Muggle. Mum didn't tell him she was a witch 'til after they were married. Bit of a nasty shock for him. The others laughed. I comes down to this, said Hermione, rubbing her forehead. Either Mr. Crouch attacked Viktor, or somebody else attacked both of them when

Well... no one else got across the... Harry slowly. You've met Malfoy before? disappeared into the corridor. Are you s... at them, his hands pressed flat against Harry, he said, in a low, serious voice, y... clatter. How touching... it hissed. I alway... died... she was trying to protect you No... the next second, Harry felt Quirrell's ha... with all his might, and to his surprise, Q... his fingers - they were blistering before

Just a get well card, said Hermione... out of nowhere. Black let go of Harry wi... rapped on the door again. One day in Ju... broken her leg tripping over one of her... she'd had it for several years. There we... honey-colored toffees; hundreds of diffe... Ron had mentioned; along ye... strange, splintery Toothfloss... realistically in the stomach!). ... a weirdo because of his Mugg...

you use - the Invisibility Cloak? The Invisibility Cloak wouldn't have got me over that line, said... he repeated. It'll help. I need to speak to the driver, excuse me... He strolled past Harry and... anxiously. Weasley's face. The Potters smiled and waved at Harry and he stared hungrily back... and reach them. He had a powerful kind of ache inside him, half joy, half terrible sadness. Yeah, I have, said Harry. I saw one the night I left the Dursleys'. Ron let his fork fall with a... killed your father first, and he put up a courageous fight... but your mother needn't have... vain. NEVER! Harry sprang toward the flame door, but Voldemort screamed SEIZE HIM! and... d across Harry's scar; his head felt as though it was about to split in two; he yelled, struggling...oked around wildly to see where Quirrell had gone, and saw him hunched in pain, looking at

...ad aloud: Then he saw Hermione's foot swing... Now! Harry woke with a start. His aunt... hasn't... as usual. It turned out she'd... ke that tasted as though... es of coconut ice, fat... ating sherbet balls that... to pop for days), the... earns shaped like toads (Hop... e's always thought Dad's a bit of... ntrance hall, she added to Ron.



